

THIS SHALL BE AN EVERLASTING STATUTE UNTO YOU

THE TEN COMMANDMENTS AND MOSAIC
LAW (c. 1300 BCE—6TH CENTURY BCE)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Divine law

BEFORE

c. 1750 BCE King Hammurabi of Babylon writes a law code.

AFTER

c. 1207 BCE An inscription on granite by Pharaoh Merneptah of Egypt is the first reference to Israelites in Canaan and boasts that “Israel is laid waste.”

3rd century BCE The Torah is translated into Greek, entitled *Pentateuch* (“five books”).

c. 200 CE Rabbis in Palestine compile a written code of Jewish oral traditions, the *Mishnah*, which offers further guidance on interpreting the laws in the Torah.

c. 350–550 CE Scholars publish the *Gemara*, an analysis and elucidation of the *Mishnah*; the two works form the *Talmud*.

Mosaic law is an ancient legal system set out in the Torah, which is the first five books of the Tanakh—the Jewish Bible, known to Christians as the Old Testament. The Torah (“instruction”) contains a great number of laws, which are presented as given directly by God to Moses, founder and lawgiver of the Jewish nation. In the legend of the Exodus, described in the Torah, Moses was ordered by God in c. 1300 BCE to lead the Israelites out of enslavement in Egypt and take them to the promised land of Canaan. Moses led his people first to Mount Sinai, which he climbed, and there God gave him the Ten Commandments,